



SOUTHEASTERN MALI is home to around 100,000 Dogon people. The

DOGON

ASTRONOMERS AND MYTH-MAKERS

majority live in small villages clustered around the foot of the 90 mile (145 km) Bandiagara Cliffs.

All dressed up

Many different Dogon ceremonies are celebrated, but the most important is the *sigui* ceremony which is held once every 60 years. Its exact date is calculated to coincide with the moment when Sirius appears between two mountain peaks. At this event power is symbolically handed over from one generation to the next and a new *toguna*, or meeting house, is built.



IN THE SHADOW OF THE CLIFFS

A group called the Tellem lived in homes carved out of the cliffs until 500 years ago. The Dogon live in the plains below but hoist their dead up to the ancient site.



DOGON RELIGIOUS SOCIETIES

All-male religious societies are an important part of Dogon life. The role of the *Wagem* cult is to keep dead ancestors involved in village affairs, while the *Binu* cult has a similar role with regard to members of the spirit world. The *Lebe* cult perform the *bulu*—an agricultural rite. It takes place just before the rains begin and its purpose is to ensure a successful harvest.

THE AWA SOCIETY

During a funeral, members of the *Awa* society lead the souls of the dead to their rightful place in the supernatural world. They wear masks indicating that they have been taken over by the souls of supernatural beings and speak a mysterious language called *sigi so*. Every 60 years the Awa society perform the most important rite of all, the *sigui*, a celebration of renewal.

